

A M B E R
RICHARD EKKEBUS



DAVID SHAW
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AMUSE BOUCHES

YUBA TARTLET

MUSHROOM CARPACCIO AND BUTTER MUSHROOM SABAYON
WITH PICKLED SHALLOT

SOYA PANNA COTTA

DAIRY-FREE PANNA COTTA MADE WITH SOYA FROM SOYBEAN
WITH A THIN LAYER OF SUMMER BACK TRUFFLE PURÉE

KATSUO

JAPANESE BONITO SASHIMI, WITH SANSHO PEPPER POWDER AND WASABI
RIBBONS OF SHAVED GRANNY SMITH APPLE AND KOHLRABI
KALE BLOSSOM AND SORREL MICROGREENS
IN A BROTH OF KOMBU AND GREEN YUZU DASHI

CAVIAR

AMBER'S SIGNATURE CAVIAR DISH
AKA UNI FROM HOKKAIDO, CAULIFLOWER SABAYON, LOBSTER JELLY
DAURENKI TSAR IMPERIAL CAVIAR
SERVED WITH SEAWEED RICE PUFF CRACKERS

OBSIBLUE

DICED OBSIBLUE PRAWN AND SAFFRON RAVIOLI
MADE WITH RICE FLOUR MIMICKING THE LOCAL WONTON
RIBBONS OF FENNEL AND DILL FLOWER
BATHING IN A WARM CONSOMMÉ MADE WITH THE HEAD OF PRAWN
INFUSED WITH ESPELETTE AND ANISE SEED

DIVER SCALLOP

HOKKAIDO SCALLOP TOPPED WITH SEA LETTUCE AND TORORO KOMBU
BATHED IN A FROTHY SAUCE OF TOASTED DASHI, LACTO FERMENTED NUT BUTTER,
AND A HOMEMADE FERMENTATION OF SCALLOP GARUM USING ALL TRIMMING OF SCALLOP
SERVED TOGETHER WITH A DAIKON-WAKAME ROLL, PAIRED WITH DAIRY FREE
SOUR CREAM MADE WITH COCONUT, SOY MILK, VINEGAR, AND KOMBU

TOOTHFISH

TOOTHFISH COVERED WITH ÑORA PEPPER AND SZECHUAN PEPPER
IN A SAUCE MADE OF LACTO-FERMENTED BELL PEPPER
SERVED WITH GRILLED CRUSTED ONION, MIZU-IKA SQUID FROM FUKUOKA, JAPAN
PICKLED WATERMELON, GINGER, AND OXALIS MICROGREENS

LAMB SADDLE

TRIPLE A LAMB SADDLE STUFFED WITH RIS DE VEAU AND SPINACH
GREEN ASPARAGUS AND MOREL MUSHROOM STUFFED WITH PARSLEY, SHALLOT, AND MINCED
LAMB TOPPED WITH DAME'S ROCKET BLOSSOM
FINISHED WITH LAMB JUS, KOJI PURÉE, AND PARSLEY PURÉE

PREMIER

DEUXIEME

LA MER ET LA TERRE

DESSERTS

PEACH

POACHED PEACH FROM TAIWAN, SURROUNDED WITH PEACH CONFIT
TOASTED MACAROON ALMONDS FROM SPAIN
FOAM OF ALMONDS AND LAVENDER MOUSSE
LAVENDER AND LAVENDER TUILE

AVOCADO

AVOCADO GELATO WITH MERINGUES
SPHERES OF SICILIAN PISTACHIO, GRANNY SMITH, AND THAI BASIL
REFRESHING LIME GEL

PETIT FOURS AND MORE

FINE TEA SELECTION

FRESH PEPPERMINT TEA WITH HONEY
EARL GREY TEA FROM JING

MIGNARDISE

RED MISO MADELEINE MADE WITH SOYBEAN FLOUR, SESAME SEED
85% DARK CHOCOLATE, GANACHE, CARAMELIZED ALMOND AND COCOA NIBS

REFRESHING FRUITS

SEASONAL FRUITS FROM A SUSTAINABLE ORGANIC FARM OF TAIWAN
LYCHEE, MANGO, AND MELON

YIN YANG

A SHAKEN MIX OF TEA AND COFFEE
OVERNIGHT INFUSED FLORAL EARL GREY TEA FROM SRI LANKA
SINGLE-ORIGIN YUNNAN COFFEE WITH AROMAS OF CARAMEL, BLACK PU'ER,
AND DARK CHOCOLATE
A SPOONFUL OF ORGANIC HONEY
FINISHED WITH DRIED ROSE PETAL

AMBER SHU

AMBER'S TAKE ON UMESHU
A SWEET, LIGHT, REFRESHING DIGESTIF
WITH A BASE OF RICE WINE AND BROWN SUGAR
INFUSED WITH YUZU

AMBER INFINITY CAKE

YUZU CHOCOLATE HAZELNUT MOUSSE CAKE
ON A STAND WITH THE SHAPE OF AMBER'S CHANDELIER BY ADAM TIHANY

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In the realm of fine dining, certain establishments transcend the mere act of dining; they become monuments of gastronomic pilgrimage. Amber, for me, embodies this transcendent experience—a culinary sanctuary that beckoned my soul for over a decade, and finally, the stars aligned for a cherished visit. Amber is more than just a fine dining restaurant; it is the singularity that ignited my enthusiasm and propelled me into the world of gastronomy. It is the beacon of enlightenment that birthed the very essence of fine dining in my culinary journey. Arriving in St. Regis's distinguished house car, we grace the entrance of the legendary Landmark Mandarin Oriental. Here, we anticipate the exquisite, personalized service awaiting us in our cherished retreat—a pied-à-terre that seamlessly blends opulence with an intimate embrace, and, naturally, the hotel's exclusive refined culinary establishment, Amber, for an unparalleled lunch degustation journey.



Upon checking in at the front desk, we are promptly ushered to the seventh floor of the hotel, where we cross the liquid-textured threshold and venture into the world of Amber. As we step into the renovated golden chamber, an elegant yet contemporary temperament soon envelops us. Seated at the window table, we immerse ourselves in the braiding of classical gracefulness and modern causality while admiring the craftsmanship of Adam Tihany: white tablecloths replaced by intricate wood tabletops, neutral-toned furnishings accented with bronze, S-shaped sofa seatings that carve the space with both private and engaging intricacy, all is enhanced with a ceiling design of gorgeous bronze ring chandeliers that floats above.

The radiant sunlight of summertime filters through a delicate veil, casting tranquil grace upon the space—a prelude to the refined ambrosia that awaits. To commence our degustation journey, we order two glasses of champagne, not only as a delightful prelude but also as a perfect pairing for the caviar course and many other anticipated seafood dishes. The Dom Pérignon 2013, with its signature silvery saline and cool minerality accented by a touch of toasty hue, exhibits an additional refreshing layer of green herbs and grassy vetiver aroma. On the other hand, the 2018 Elemart Robion 'Les Monets' Blanc de Noirs soon distinguishes itself from the Dom Pérignon with its opulent fruity ripeness and depth. The essential darker tone of a blanc de noirs, doubled with the higher dosage, depicts a psychedelic orchard in the glass.

Renovated three years ago after a four-month hiatus, the restaurant underwent a significant change in its concept as well. Chef Richard Ekkebus has done away with dairy and reduced sugar and salt, opting for alternatives such as soy, rice, cereal, and nut milk in place of dairy; fermentation and products like seaweed instead of salt; and agave, maple, honey, and raw sugar in lieu of traditional sugar. This concept is well interwoven into the first two bites: a Yuba tartlet of mushroom carpaccio and butter mushroom sabayon complemented by pickled shallot, and a soybean panna cotta with a thin layer of summer black truffle purée.



While we are reluctant to part with the raw mushroom and soy panna cotta, which effortlessly summon a refreshing and linear breeze to counter the intensity of summer's warmth with immediate grace, we soon transition seamlessly to the next course, offering quintessential lightness in the Japanese manner. Presenting katsuo sashimi, this dish unveils three meticulously prepared pieces of katsuo, adorned with the subtle allure of sansho pepper powder and wasabi. The authentic Japanese sashimi is crowned with delicate ribbons of shaved Granny Smith apple and kohlrabi. The Granny Smith apple imparts an additional stratum of acute acidity, seamlessly intertwining a subtle European nuance into the Japanese masterpiece. Simultaneously, the kohlrabi reveals its distinctive, peppery daikon-esque flavor profile, evoking a subtle nod to Scandinavian gastronomy. This harmonious symphony finds its repose in a pond of kombu broth and green yuzu dashi, where the dynamic duo of kombu and green yuzu mirrors the nuanced interplay of the Granny Smith and kohlrabi. To embellish the ensemble, kale blossoms and sorrel microgreens make their entrance, bestowing the dish with a tapestry of herbal and citrusy vibrancy.



A pilgrimage to Amber remains incomplete without savoring its *pièce de résistance* — the caviar dish with uni and cauliflower purée. Far from groundbreaking or visually shocking, this culinary masterpiece is, in fact, an old friend, set against a backdrop we know well — the artful pairing of seafood and crustacean jelly, a technique perfected by culinary maestros such as Joël Robuchon, Alain Ducasse, and Guillaume Galliot of the renowned Caprice. Yet, the joy is immeasurable when this familiar setting proves to be a source of unbridled delight. The pristine Hokkaido aka uni, reaching its pinnacle in early June, unfolds as a symphony of sweetness and umami, unleashing a tropical fruit tsunami through its creamy texture. Its refined mellowness echoes the lusciousness of a fully ripened Thai mango, harmonizing flawlessly with the elegant nuttiness and velvety consistency of the cauliflower sabayon. Introducing a marine depth, the lobster jelly contributes another layer of oceanic umami, showcasing the linear and mineral facets of the sea, in stark contrast to the uni's indulgent richness. Crowning this culinary medley is the generous dome of imperial caviar, bestowing an explosive umami bomb upon the ensemble. On the side, a large rectangular piece of seaweed rice puff crackers further invites diners to relish each exquisite bite in a setting reminiscent of Russia's old caviar tradition, yet reimagined with serene Japanese undertones. Amber's signature dish transcends the ordinary, weaving together familiar elements into a tapestry of unparalleled culinary bliss.







The subsequent dish ushers in a whisper of tranquility — a culinary zen encapsulated within a bowl resembling a Buddhist bronze singing bowl. Here, a modern interpretation of wonton soup unfolds. Filled with diced precious Obsibblue prawn from France and saffron, the ravioli, despite its nomenclature, unveils itself more akin to a wonton with its delicate rice flour wrap. The choice of rice flour imparts a subtler flavor profile, surpassing even the traditional pasta dough in this context. The ethereal quality of the wonton rice flour acts like a translucent veil, elegantly allowing the umami of Obsibblue shrimp to fully shine through. Furthermore, the shrimp's texture is impeccably executed — succulent and tender, delivering a gratifyingly springy and resilient chewiness. Adorned with ribbons of fennel and dill flower, the wontons are then bathed in a warm head prawn consommé infused with espelette and anise seed. The consommé boasts an exceptionally light and gentle texture, reminiscent of Cantonese wonton soup. Nonetheless, it diverges with a generous infusion of prawn head essence, espelette, and anise seed. In this vibrant concoction, the lively Basque Piment d'Espelette intertwines with the aromatic Cantonese star anise, blending fiery hues with rustic textures, evoking a passionate spirit. This enchanting fusion of iconic spices from two distinct cultures beautifully unites them in a magical culinary encounter. Chef Richard Ekkebus, with his magic touch, breathes new life into the Cantonese street delight, birthing a reimagined masterpiece that resonates with the Zen-like essence with a hint of introversive fieriness embodied in every bite.



If the previous Wonton soup eloquently wove together the traditions of Cantonese and Basque cuisine, the ensuing dish stands as a testament to the ingenious marriage of Japanese ingredients reimaged through a Scandinavian lens. Renowned for their mutual mastery of fermentation, both Japan and the Scandinavian region share a culinary philosophy that celebrates the intrinsic flavors of ingredients, favoring lighter sauces in contrast to the richness found in Western European cuisines. This concept seamlessly aligns with Chef Ekkebus's culinary philosophy, emphasizing non-dairy milks, fermentation, and the use of seaweed in lieu of salt—a vision well-suited to the restaurant's harbor location that pays homage to the abundance of fresh seafood. In this exquisite presentation, two pristine scallop shells cradle a visually arresting tableau, as though the scallop has been freshly caught from the sea and laid directly before us. One side reveals an entire Hokkaido scallop, bathing in a frothy concoction of toasted dashi, lacto-fermented nut butter, and a homemade fermentation of scallop garum using all trimming of the scallop. This captivating blend of Japanese dashi and Viking lacto-fermentation techniques yields a sumptuous umami experience, cloaked in an ethereal foamy texture. The scallop is then crowned with sea lettuce and tororo kombu, imparting a sophisticated umami and brininess while creating a visual illusion of the duo resting within the shell, unveiled before our eyes. On the other side of the shell unfolds a more elaborate scene — a meticulously layered roll featuring daikon and wakame, accompanied by a quenelle of dairy-free sour cream crafted from coconut, soy milk, vinegar, and kombu. Both daikon and wakame, integral to Japanese cuisine, are intricately woven into a roll reminiscent of the shape of a scallop flesh. Paired with the quenelle of sour cream, this culinary masterpiece announces itself with a symphony of gorgeous acidity and oceanic umami, delivered through a creamy, tender touch.



As chef Ekkebus returns to the realm of European cuisine, the seafood main course reveals an unforeseen, resplendently aureate seascape depicting toothfish with layers of fiery luster and coruscating nuances. The medallion of toothfish is first delicately covered with ñora pepper and szechuan pepper then encircled with a rich lacto-fermented bell pepper purée. With a mere one-tenth of the spiciness found in cayenne pepper, the mild ñora pepper unfolds with a rich earthy sweetness. Underscored by the subtle numbness imparted by the Szechuan pepper, this pepper duo blankets the toothfish with an intrinsic layer of vibrance and brilliance. Following its journey through the lacto-fermentation process, the bell pepper purée now carries nuanced hints of unique sourness and umami, accentuating its inherent sweetness. The delightful interplay of sour and savory notes serves to kindle the palate, yet maintains a subtlety that allows the toothfish to shine on its own. Garnished with grilled crusted onion, mizu-ika squid from Fukuoka, pickled watermelon, ginger, and oxalis microgreens, the medley is further enrich with hints of restricted refreshingness.



In the pursuit of a classical French culinary masterpiece, Chef Ekkebus unveils the crowning jewel of the degustation journey — a land course featuring two impeccably seared medallions of lamb saddle, generously stuffed with ris de veau and spinach. The lamb saddle, a marvel in itself, graces the palate with a golden hue and tenderness akin to a celestial kiss. The knife effortlessly glides through the meat, guided by its own weight. The ris de veau inlay, with its luxuriously rich gamey nuttiness and buttery umami reminiscent of foie gras, imparts a sumptuous layer to the lamb, akin to the lusciousness of veal fat, adorned with a gorgeous layer of milky tones and nuanced land game flavors. Nestled within, the embedded spinach, boasting a creamy texture, releases a precious layer of delicate sweetness and acidic green notes, delicately cleansing the palate of any lingering richness from the medallion. This meticulously crafted mosaic of lamb saddle finds its counterpart in two morels, artfully stuffed with parsley, shallot, and minced lamb, crowned with dame's rocket blossom. The morels themselves exude a mesmerizing toasted nutty earthy aroma, further enriched by the lamb nestled within. The shallot and parsley introduce additional layers of aroma to the mushroom. In addition, the unique structure of morel mushrooms enables them to absorb an array of flavors, reaching perfection. Then on the plate, koji purée and parsley purée are further introduced, weaving in another touch of multicultural flavors. Culminating in a textbook traditional French garnish, the medley is gracefully crowned with asparagus and lamb jus, completing this culinary symphony with a harmonious blend of classical French techniques and flavors.



Ensuing the ambitiously rich and vibrant main courses from both land and sea, our palates are treated to two refreshing desserts, each intricately celebrating the nuanced symphony of multi-layered fruit flavors, unveiling a microcosm of exquisite details within every bite. The first dessert, themed around the mesmerizing dreamy marriage of peach and lavender, unravels a tapestry of textures and layers, seamlessly intertwined to create a romantic *liebestraum* beyond imagination. In this enchanting creation, poached peaches from Taiwan and peach confit gracefully dance in perfect harmony with three textures of lavender. Here the lavender not only graces the dish in its pure form but also transforms into a velvety mousse and a delicate purple tuile resembling an angel's wing. The introduction of toasted macaroon almonds from Spain adds a foundation of creamy nuttiness, while the ethereal espuma elevates the heavenly beauty with an irresistibly light sigh.



If the purple paysage, themed around the enchanting combination of peach and lavender, unfolds in an ethereal dreamland, the subsequent course, adorned in gradient hues of green, transports us to the most naive and innocent realm of pure joy. Showcasing the versatile avocado, this fruit takes center stage in the guise of gelato and meringue, accompanied by its vibrant companions—Sicilian pistachio, Granny Smith apple, Thai basil, and the lime. The Sicilian pistachio, with its earthy nuttiness and glossy sweetness, speaks a language native to the avocado's homeland, echoing buttery, creamy, nutty, earthy, and grassy undertones. In contrast, the Granny Smith apple, Thai basil, and lime contribute a lively counterpoint with their bright acidity and fully aromatic herbal fragrance, creating a symphony of flavors that dances on the palate.







Just as we anticipate the conclusion of our degustation journey, an unexpectedly luxurious banquet unfolds before us, constituting a micro tasting menu in its own right. Commencing with a selection of exquisite teas from the local company Jing, the menu invites us to choose from their fine offerings. Presently, two pots of freshly brewed peppermint tea with honey and classical Earl Grey are elegantly presented in modern transparent glass tea sets. Following this, a sumptuous carte of mignardise graces the scene. On the trolley, we find a red miso Madeleine crafted with soybean flour and sesame seeds, alongside a dark chocolate delicacy featuring ganache, caramelized almond, and cocoa nibs. Both creations, utilizing non-dairy products, reimagine classical French bites in a delicate, yet refreshingly modern presentation.

Adding to the delightful finale, a refreshing fruit plate shows up on the table. Showcasing lychee, mango, and melon sourced from a sustainable organic farm in Taiwan, this selection defies traditional expectations of petit fours with such fruit plate aligns with the typical and satisfying conclusion to a meal found in Japanese and Chinese cuisine.



The complimentary tea selection is already a rare indulgence in today's fine dining landscape, yet Amber takes generosity a step further. While many luxurious establishments with tasting menu may offer complimentary cocktails at the beginning of the meal, Amber pleasantly surprised me with two more exceptional cocktails following the mignardise. The first, aptly named Yin Yang, is a meticulously shaken blend of tea and coffee. The overnight-infused floral Earl Grey tea from Sri Lanka seamlessly harmonizes with the single-origin Yunnan coffee, releasing aromas of caramel, black pu'er, and dark chocolate. This harmonious union yields a beverage that would no doubt linger in one's memory for decades. It is then further elevated with a spoonful of organic honey and adorned with dried rose petals, providing not only a delightful taste but also a visual treat. In a private honorary gesture, moved by our shared passion for gastronomy, the waiter further presented us with a complimentary second cocktail named Amber Shu, which usually only offered during dinner service. A unique take on Umeshu, it features a base of rice wine and brown sugar infused with yuzu, resulting in a sweet, light, and refreshing digestif that serves as the perfect conclusion to the meal. Continuing the narrative of Amber's extraordinary generosity, the restaurant surpassed expectations by presenting us not only with two exceptional cocktails but also with its signature Infinity Cake of Yuzu chocolate hazelnut mousse. Delicately showcased on a stand mirroring the shape of Amber's iconic chandelier designed by Adam Tihany, this gesture elevated the dining experience to unparalleled heights. It's a rarity to encounter complimentary cake executed to such finesse at any restaurant, let alone one that offers such a generous portion capable of constituting another remarkable meal in itself.













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In essence, this lavish finale epitomizes a remarkable finesse, seamlessly threaded with a consistent theme of linear lightness that echoes Chef Ekkebus's innovative philosophy. Whether sipping tea or savoring mignardise, indulging in cocktails or marveling at the grandeur of the Infinity Cake, Amber's brilliant team not only reinforced the restaurant's dedication to culinary indulgence but also crafted an exceptionally rare scene in the heart of the gastronomic world. The culinary opulence at Amber, from meticulously crafted savories to decadent sweets, has etched an unforgettable gastronomic journey that transcends the confines of conventional fine dining experiences. As this pilgrimage to Amber concludes, we submerge in such a moment of perfection, where our hearts find in eternity the utmost joy and satisfaction.

